Debate

Teaching with AI (TAI)

Mirte van der Eyden[1], Andrea López Incera[2]

[1] Institut für Fachdidaktik, Universität Innsbruck
mirte.van-der-eyden@uibk.ac.at

[2] Departament de didàctica de la matemàtica i les ciències experimentals, Universitat Autònoma de Barcelona
andrea.lopez.incera@uab.cat

Project funded by Erasmus+ Programme of the European Union

Subject: Debate about AI
Activity duration: 180 min

Steps:

1. Distribute debate themes and prepare in groups (90 min)
2. Debate in groups (90 min)

Learning goals:

- Doing research about an ethical topic
- Preparing arguments
- Debate

Debate

on ethics and practical consequences of AI

Here we share a list of suggested topics for a debate about AI. Students get assigned a Thesis and a side (for/against) in groups of 2 or 3. They get time to do research and prepare their arguments. Then, they will have a debate with the other side. The students in de audience each prepare a question. Afterwards, two students in the audience are appointed to ask a question.

Debate Topics on AI

Each topic has a short thesis, a simple explanation, and two sides (For / Against). Students argue for or against the thesis.

1. **Thesis: AI-made works should be allowed to have copyright.**
   What this means: If a human uses AI to make images, music, or text, can that human own the rights like an author?
   For:

   - The human still makes choices: prompts, edits, and selection show creativity.
   - It motivates people to invest time and money in creative AI.
   - Tools have always changed art (like cameras); authorship can include new tools.

   Against:

   - Copyright is for human authors; fully machine-made work should not qualify.
   - Could create a flood of protected machine content and legal problems.
   - Other options (contracts, licenses) may fit better than copyright.

2. **Thesis: The environmental cost of generative AI is bigger than its benefits.**
   What this means: Training and using big AI models uses a lot of electricity and water. Is it worth it?
   For:

   - Data centers use much energy and water; local communities pay the price.
   - Many AI uses are low-value or replace simpler methods.
   - The same resources could support health, climate, or public services.

   Against:

   - AI can save energy in other areas (smart grids, transport, buildings).
   - Chips and data centers are getting more efficient.
   - Rules and clean energy can reduce the harm without stopping progress.

3. **Thesis: AI companions and creative tools are good for mental health.**
   What this means: Chatbots and AI art/music tools might help people feel better.
   For:

   - Easy to access, no stigma; good for journaling and reflection.
   - Can reduce loneliness and support coping skills.
   - Early studies show mood benefits when used with care.

   Against:

   - People may become dependent and talk less to real friends.
   - Bots can give wrong or unsafe advice.
   - Privacy risks: sensitive data could be misused.

4. **Thesis: Students should be allowed to use generative AI in arts and humanities assignments.**
   What this means: Can students use tools like chatbots or image generators for class work?
   For:

   - Matches real creative work today; teaches how to guide and improve AI output.
   - Helps with brainstorming and feedback for all students.
   - With clear rules and citation, it supports learning.

   Against:

   - Makes it hard to judge a student's own skills.
   - Tempts students to shortcut and weakens basics (writing, analysis, technique).
   - Not all students have equal access; tools can be biased.

5. **Thesis: Using public internet content to train AI is fair use.**
   What this means: Is it okay for companies to scrape online text and images to train AI without asking each creator?
   For:

   - The training is transformative (learning patterns, not copying exact works).
   - Needed for useful AI; similar to text and data mining.
   - Society benefits from better tools and knowledge.

   Against:

   - It takes creators' work without permission or pay.
   - AI outputs can replace the original creators' market.
   - Publicly available does not mean free to use; privacy and website rules matter.

6. **Thesis: AI-made art is art.**
   What this means: Should works made with or by AI be accepted as "art"?
   For:

- Art depends on intention, context, and audience—not only on the tool.
- Humans still choose prompts, curate results, and set meaning.
- Art history shows new media (photo, video, code) become accepted.

Against:

- AI lacks human feeling and agency inside the work.
- Often imitates styles; may lead to sameness and pastiche.
- Can shift focus from human craft to automation.

7. **Thesis: Teachers should use AI to make teaching materials and help evaluate students.**
   What this means: Is it good for teachers to use AI to prepare lessons, quizzes, and feedback?
   For:

   - Saves time so teachers can focus on students.
   - Helps personalize learning and improve accessibility.
   - Can support clear rubrics and spot learning gaps.

   Against:

   - AI can be biased or wrong; grading may become less fair or clear.
   - Risks to student privacy and data security.
   - Could weaken teacher skills and relationships with students.

8. **Thesis: In creative and cultural jobs, AI will cause more job losses than new jobs.**
   What this means: Will AI take away more jobs (designers, writers, translators, etc.) than it creates?
   For:

   - Fast replacement in illustration, content writing, and post-production.
   - Lower pay and fewer entry-level opportunities.
   - Big tech firms capture most value, not individual creators.

   Against:

   - New jobs appear (model trainers, prompt experts, curators, verifiers).
   - Higher productivity can grow markets and demand.
   - History shows tech changes jobs more than it removes them over time.

9. **Thesis: People must say when they used AI in academic or creative work.**
   What this means: Should students, writers, and artists disclose AI help in their work?
   For:

- Builds trust and protects academic honesty.
- Gives proper credit and shows the human's real contribution.
- Helps with copyright, safety checks, and provenance.

Against:

- Hard to enforce when AI is built into many tools.
- Might discourage experimentation with useful tools.
- Some say the result matters more than which tool was used.

Optional tips for students

- Define key words at the start in 1–2 simple sentences (e.g., copyright," fair use," "disclosure").
- Use clear examples: a news article on AI energy use, a school policy, a court case, a real artist's experience.
- Agree on team roles: one introduces, one gives evidence, one rebuts and closes.